The Dark Swordsman

The Beginning of the End



Ruslan Rudniev

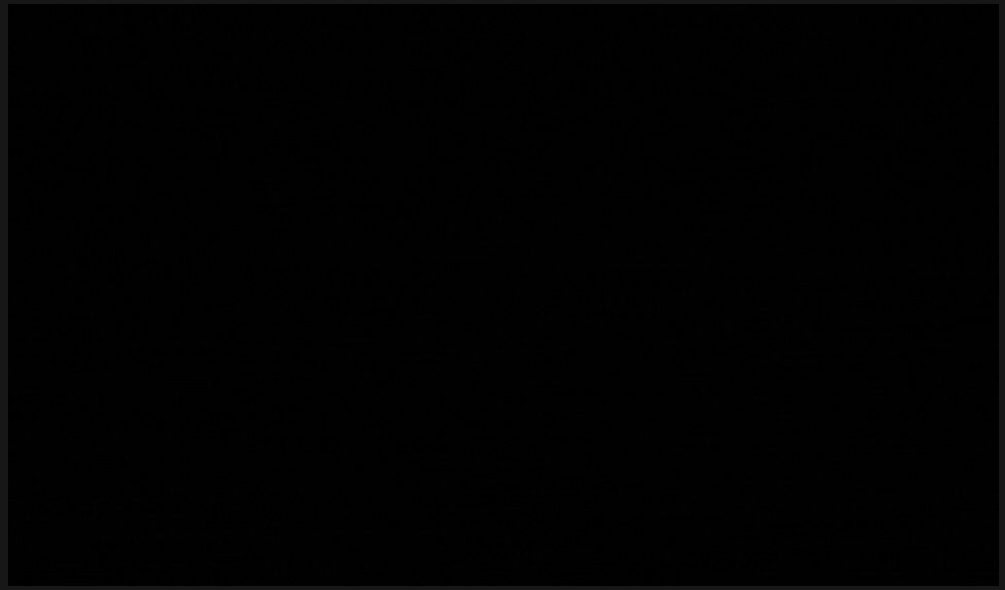
ABOUT THE GAME

Genre:
Story-Rich • First-Person Action • Adventure

Platform:
PC

Core Concept:

- Story based game
- Berserk inspired story
- Dark Fantasy world
- Linear, up to 20 hours game
- Combat elements



TARGET AUDIENCE

Fans of *Berserk* Deeply emotional dark fantasy with a tragic, lone warrior at its center

- Themes of **revenge**, **regret**, **existential pain**, and **cursed immortality**
- Dark atmosphere, personal struggle, and poetic sadness
- Love immersive, symbolic storytelling



People who wants Linear games

Linear games that doesn't last 50+ hours. People wants to play now and not spend time on unnecessary farm

- Enjoy the game from the beginning
- Story rich with motion cutscenes
- Unique gameplay elements



MARKET SIZE

Overview:

The most relevant audience is the fanbase of Berserk. By September 2023, the Berserk manga had over 60 million copies, including digital versions.

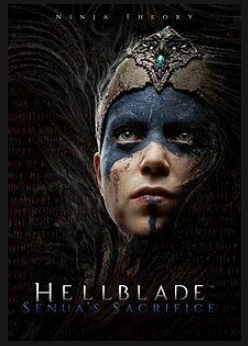
Berserk has also inspired a number of video games, including the Dynasty Warriors series, the Final Fantasy series, the Dark Souls series, Bloodborne, Capcom's Devil May Cry and Dragon's Dogma series. Total number of copies sold globally is 422.3 million.
Now let's narrow the broad industry-wide figure based on our realistic assumption of market interest to the game and apply a Top-Down Market Sizing methodology.

Let's assume 7% of these 422.3 million players are highly aligned with The Dark Swordsman's dark fantasy, emotional narrative, and challenge-driven gameplay.

Franchise/ Game Series	Copies Sold (millions)
Dynasty Warriors	65
Final Fantasy	200
Dark Souls	27
Bloodborne	7.46
Sekiro: Shadows Die Twice	10
Elden Ring	28.6
Capcom's Devil May Cry	30
Dragon's Dogma	1.7

Adjusted Addressable Market = 7% × 422.3M = ~29,561,000 million players.

COMPETITORS



Hellblade: Senua's Sacrifice

- Dark, emotional narrative
- Strong female protagonist

Successful game (1M+ units)



Dark Souls

- Challenging combats
- Deep lore, minimal direct storytelling
- Dark fantasy environments

Massive cult following & bestseller



Last of us

- Powerful characters
- Emotional story
- Linear gameplay

Successful game (10M+ units)

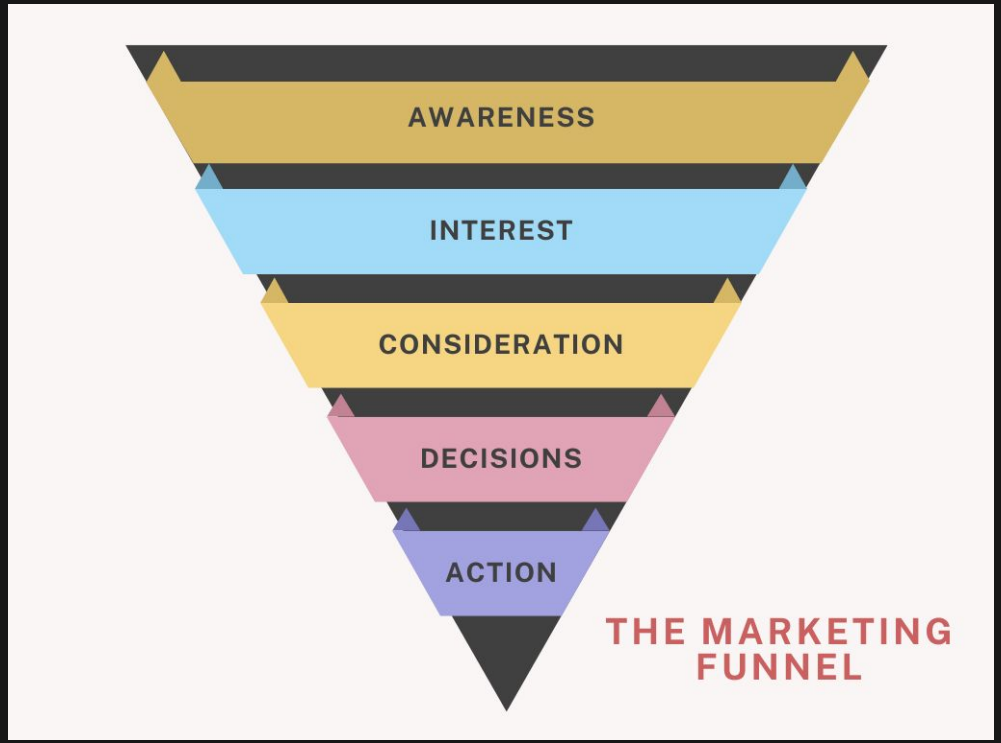


Indika

- Indie developers
- Emotional story supported with cutscenes
- Linear story based game with philosophical meaning

Example game

Marketing Funnel

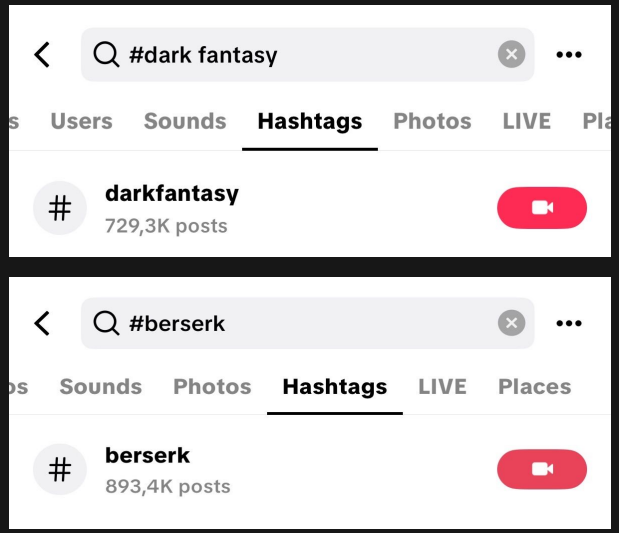


Awareness & Interest: Social Media

Platform:
TikTok

Marketing Strategy:

- Launch trailer of the game
- Use hashtags like - “berserk”; “dark fantasy”
- Patch Updates in the future
- Short action videos from the game



Social Media

Platform:
YouTube

Marketing Strategy:

- Post Launch/Demo trailers
- Post Update patch videos
- Post other long last supporting materials of the game





Social Media

Platform:
X | Instagram

Marketing Strategy:

- Post announcements
- Post Fragments of the game
- Post news about the company & talk videos
- Communicate with the audience

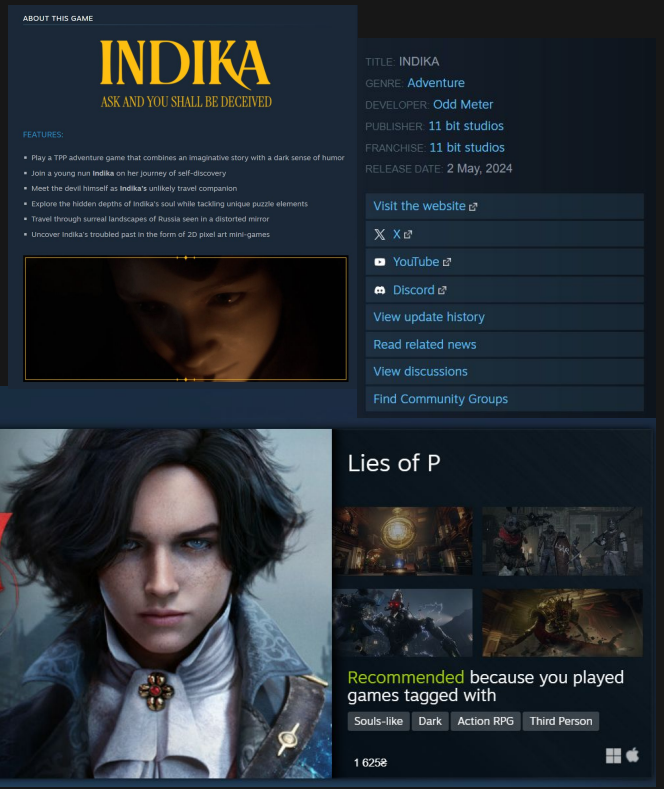


Recommendation Engine

Platform:
Steam

Marketing Strategy:

- Genre Placement
- Great Visually Supporting Materials
- Links to social medias



Conference

Events:
Steam Next Fest

Marketing Strategy:

- Present a Gameplay Trailer
- Playable Demo
- Mentions from journalists & content creators



Consideration & Decision: Demo Release

Platform:
Steam

Impact:

- Gives opportunity to gather early player feedback
- Increase chances of wishlists/full release traction
- Give opportunity to attract influencers to play it



Pre-Order Bonuses

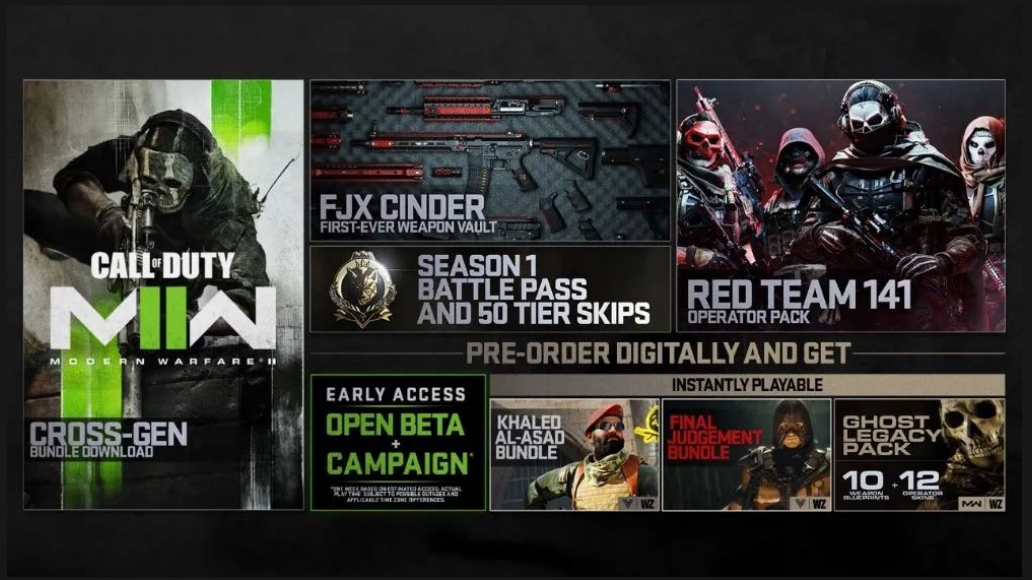
Platform:
Steam

Marketing Strategy:

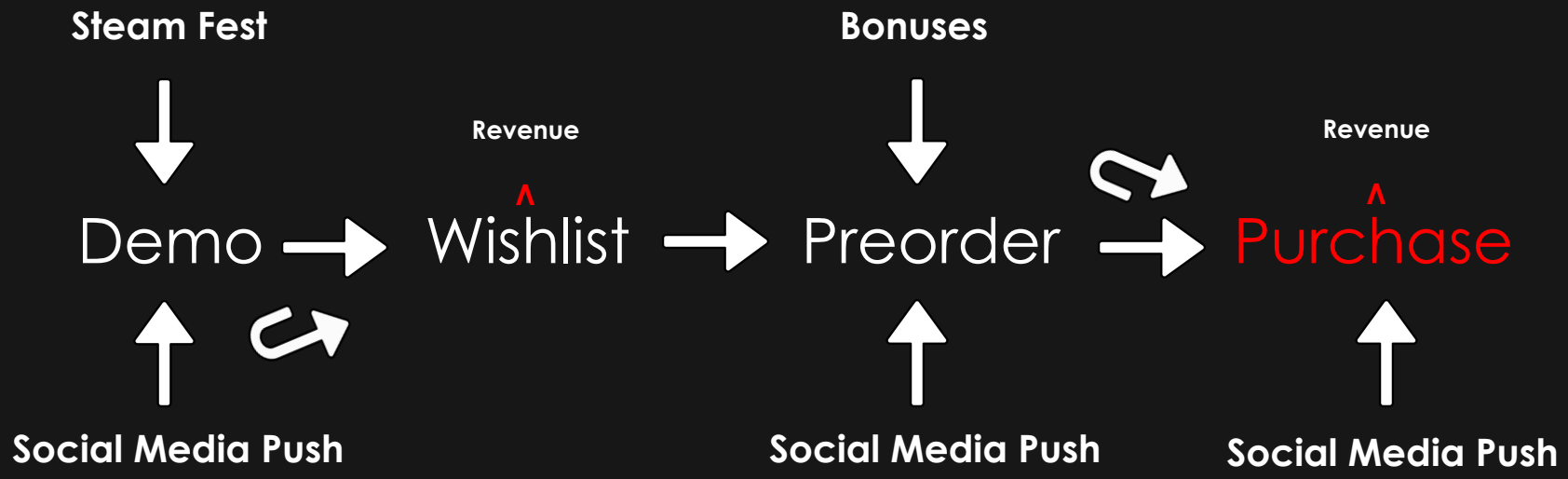
- Gives 2 weeks early access
- Adds on (Art Book & Soundtrack)

Impact:

- Boosts early revenue
- Adds perceived value



Action: Purchase



Monetization: One Time Purchase

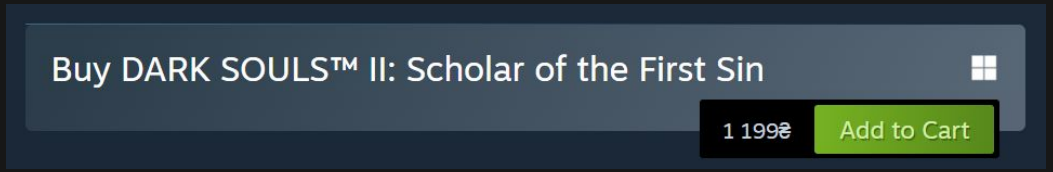
Platform:
Steam|Direct Sales

Cost:
25 euro



Pros:

- Simple and well known (builds trust)
- Ideal for narrative/ single player
- Higher upfront revenue per user



Monetization: DLC & Ads On

Platform:
Steam|Direct Sales

Cost:
4.99 euro : DLC

Pros:

- Keeps the community engaged longer after launch
- Best monetization in order to gain money & not ruin the experience
- Doesn't require a lot in production cost



Monetization: Bundles

Platform:
Steam|Direct Sales

Cost:
Standard Edition: 24.99 euro
Deluxe Edition: 29.99 euro
Extreme Edition : 34.99 euro

Info:

- Standard Edition - Includes the game (+20 hours of gameplay)
- Deluxe Edition: Includes Art Book & Original Soundtrack
- Extreme Edition: Includes DLC & All Customizations

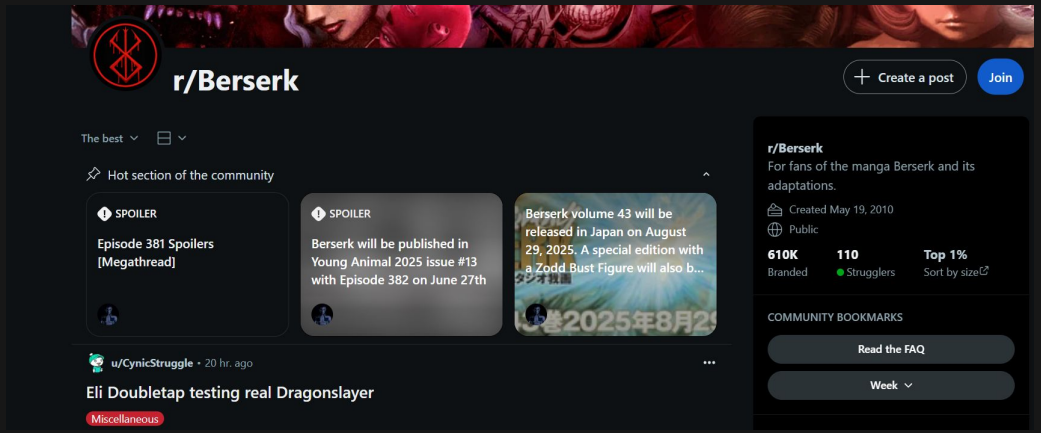


Community Engagement

Platform:
Reddit|Discord Servers

Impact:

- Track the target audience reactions on the game (before release)
- Keep in contact with target audience directly
- Analyze target audience feedback about the game



TEAM BUDGET

Period (months)	Position	Involvement	Salary (€)	Budget (€)
24	Product Owner/ Game Designer	100%	4000	96000
24	Unity Developer/ Tech Lead	100%	4000	96000
24	Product Manager	100%	4000	96000
24	3D Artist	50%	4000	3600
24	QA Tester	50%	3000	36000

Total cost: €360000

PROMOTION BUDGET

Category	Budget (€)
Awareness	40000
Consideration	16000
Conversion	28000

Total cost: €84000

Production

Direction	Category	Cost (€)	Notes
Infrastructure & Tools	Game Engine Licenses	500	Unity is free until €100K revenue, but Pro or plugins may cost
Infrastructure & Tools	3D Modeling Tools	1200	Blender (free) or Autodesk Maya/3ds Max (subscription)
Infrastructure & Tools	Version Control (Git, etc.)	300	GitHub Teams, GitKraken, or similar tools
Infrastructure & Tools	Project Management Tools	300	Tools like Trello Premium, or Jira
Infrastructure & Tools	Cloud Storage & Backup	500	Google Drive, Dropbox, AWS, or Backblaze
Infrastructure & Tools	Hardware	4000	PC, Monitor, etc
Infrastructure & Tools	Software Licenses	1200	Adobe Creative Cloud, ReSharper, Visual Studio Pro, etc.
Infrastructure & Tools	Miscellaneous Tools	1000	Asset store purchases, script packs, dev tools
Sound Design	Voice, Music, Sound	10000	Sound Designer (Freelance); Original Soundtrack (Composer); Voice Acting (Actors & Direction)

Total cost: €19000



TIMELINE: GAME DEVELOPMENT STAGES

Early 2025
Concepting & Prototyping

Mid/Late 2025 – Mid 2026
Full Production + Iterative User Testing (Agile Workflow)

Late 2026 – Early 2027
Final Testing & Polishing

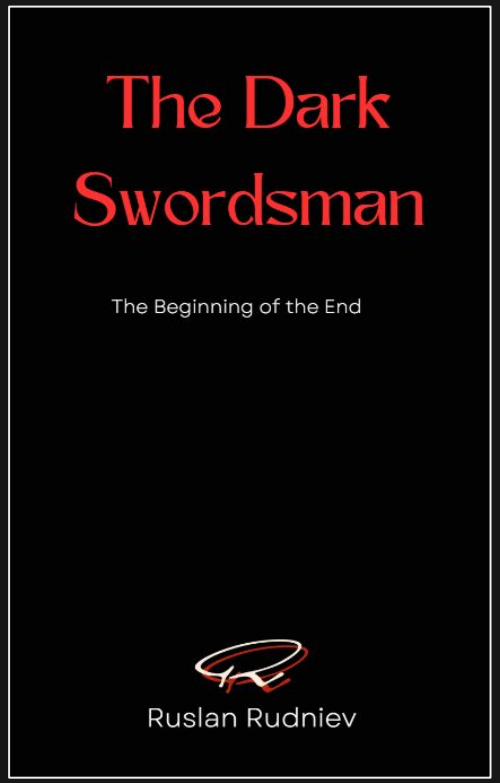
Mid 2027
Start of the Marketing Active Phase

Late 2027
Release on Platforms

Mid 2028
Release DLC|Customization|Bundles



LEARN MORE



Appendix

Product





Overview

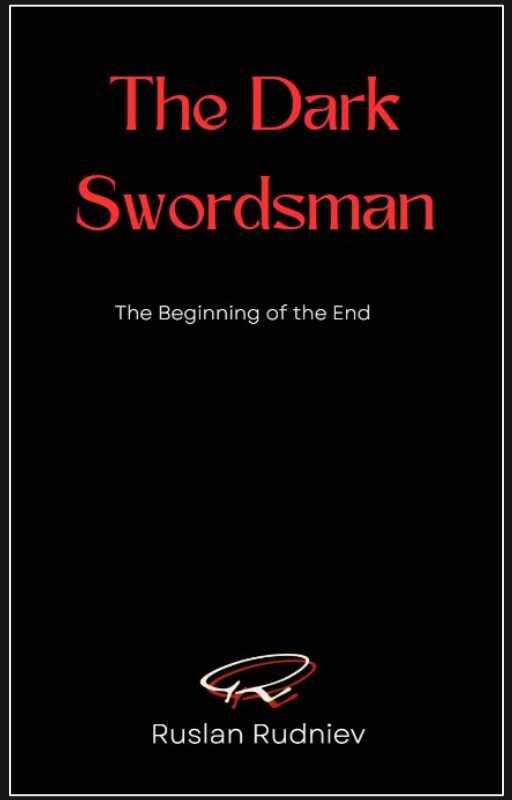
MY PRODUCT

The Dark Swordsman is a dark fantasy, story-driven adventure game that blends immersive storytelling, emotional depth, and realistic sword-based combat.

Players take on the role of a cursed warrior trapped in an endless cycle of life and death, forced to fight demons in order to reclaim his mortality and peace of mind.

Inspired by Berserk, the game offers a cinematic, first-person experience built around philosophical themes such as regret, revenge, and the search for meaning.

Unlike traditional games that rely heavily on combat or exploration alone, The Dark Swordsman focuses on emotional storytelling and atmosphere, inviting players into a haunting yet deeply human journey.



CORE GAMEPLAY & FEATURES

Realistic Melee Combat:
No health bars combat is lethal and immersive, rewarding precision, timing, and strategy.

Narrative-Driven Progression:
Rich, emotionally resonant storytelling through interactive dialogues and motion-captured cutscenes.

Atmospheric World Design:
A carefully crafted world that reflects the protagonist's internal battle through dynamic lighting, soundscapes, and environmental storytelling in a Dark fantasy setting.

Linear Level Structure:
Designed for players who prefer structured narratives over sprawling open worlds; each level is crafted to progress the story meaningfully.

Psychological Themes:
The game is intended to be more than entertainment, addressing loneliness, grief, and self-discovery through interactive storytelling.

TECHNICAL DETAILS

Engine:
Unity (planned prototype); possible migration to Unreal Engine 5 for enhanced graphics and cinematic capabilities in later stages.

Platform:
PC (initial release via Steam); potential for console release (PlayStation/Xbox) in later stages.

Graphics:
Realistic 3D environments with detailed shaders, VFX, and custom animations.

Audio:
Original soundtrack with mood-driven dynamic audio. Voice acting and ambient soundscapes will support emotional immersion.

Development Tools:
Blender for 3D modeling, FMOD/Wwise for audio design, and Git for version control.

Team Expertise:
3 core members covering game design, development, and marketing; supported by an organizational coach and industry advisors.

Monetization:
Premium game model with a single-purchase price. Potential for DLCs based on player feedback.

CURRENT STATUS

Game Design Document (GDD)
is fully completed, providing a comprehensive vision, mechanics, and production roadmap for the game.

Minimum Viable Product (MVP) of Level 1
has been developed and is functional, serving as an early proof-of-concept for gameplay and core mechanics.

Prototype development
is underway, with an expected delivery timeline of 6–8 months. This phase will focus on expanding the core gameplay, refining mechanics, and building out more content to establish the foundation for full production.

Development Tools:
Blender for 3D modeling, FMOD/Wwise for audio design, and Git for version control.

The core team
is in the process of formation.

The critical reviews from business decision makers
have been received and incorporated into the game development plan.

Customer





Segments

MAIN TARGET AUDIENCE

For the customer segment of my product, I did research where the gap of the market and what audience is currently starving for content, as that will be safer to launch a first game if you already know who will buy your product.

My main target audience for the game is a Berserk fan base, which is huge and currently starving for the content, as there is no further development either in Anime, and nothing in the game market.

Berserk is a Japanese manga series written and illustrated by Kentaro Miura. Even the fans themselves started donating their own money for fan made development, so the question is why not just give them the content that they want?

As my game has a Berserk inspired story and the setting, it will get their attention which will also help in pushing the game at the start on social media.



ADDITIONAL CUSTOMER SEGMENT

Whose life situation will be:

Came back from work/university and they don't want/have to spend time exploring farming in the game, they want a game that fills with content every time doesn't last long;

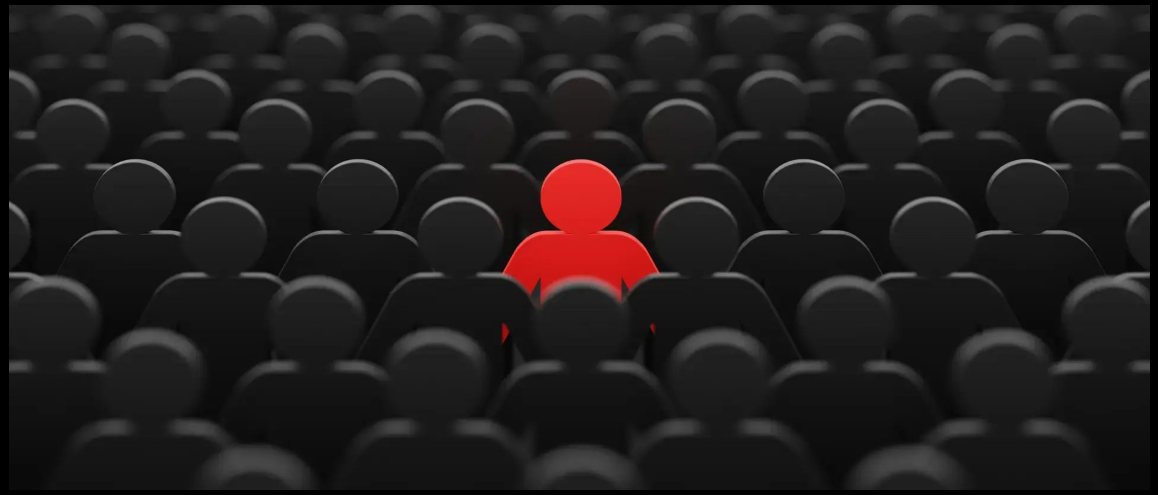
Their social life situation:

Young adults who are struggling to find themselves in life, as my game touches a philosophical meaning of the point of life, it might help them and grab their attention.

Their interests:

Young adults who are interested in philosophy, dark fantasy games/books/movies and like novels with dramatical stories that go around the protagonists.

Unique Value Proposition



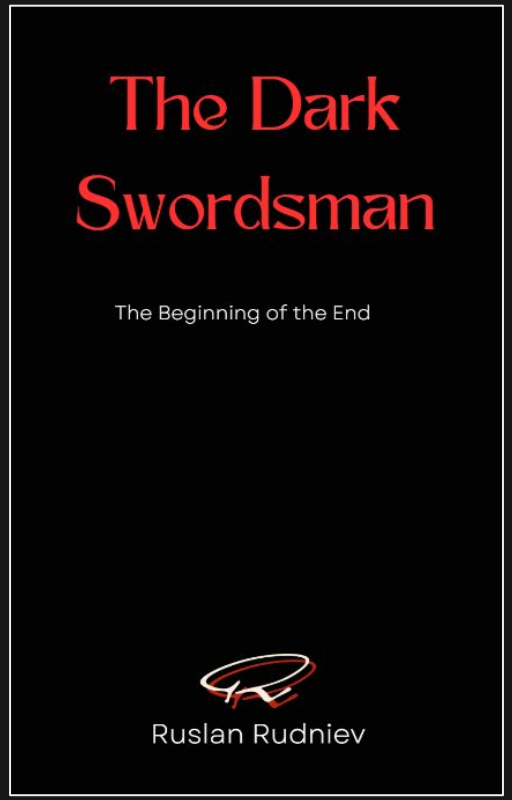
Highlights

OVERVIEW

The Dark Swordsman offers more than entertainment, it delivers an emotionally resonant, therapeutic experience for players struggling with feelings of loneliness, hopelessness, or disconnection.

Through a dark, immersive atmosphere and a powerful, narrative-driven journey, the game helps players explore their inner world, find emotional connection, and experience personal reflection in a meaningful way.

Unlike many combat-focused fantasy games (The Evolution of Fantasy Combat, 2025), The Dark Swordsman combines realistic sword mechanics with deep psychological storytelling. It stands out by addressing mental health themes through immersive gameplay, creating a space where players feel understood, not just entertained.



KEY CHARACTERISTICS

A Game About Inner Strength:
It is more than combat, it's about facing pain, finding purpose, and growing stronger through every challenge. A powerful emotional journey that sets it apart from typical action games.

Not Just a Game - A Personal Journey
Players walk side-by-side with the protagonist through regret, love, loss, and redemption.

A Linear Experience, Rich in Depth
Designed for players who are tired of massive open worlds. It delivers a focused, tightly written adventure where every scene matters

Emotional Storytelling with Real Impact
Built to leave a mark, with cinematic moments, deep character emotions, and choices that make players reflect on their own life.

Challenge with Meaning:
Every battle has a purpose. Every moment of struggle pushes the player and the character forward.

For Players Who Want More:
Perfect for those who crave stories that go beyond fantasy-stories that are raw, real, and unforgettable.

PROBLEM & SOLUTION

Problem:

Many players today face emotional challenges such as loneliness, anxiety, or a lack of meaning, yet most games focus solely on action, competition, or escapism. There is a lack of emotionally supportive, narrative-driven games that speak directly to players' inner struggles while still offering engaging gameplay. Moreover, big companies like Ubisoft are trying to make the games as big as possible, to make players spend more time in it and donate.

With that problem people just don't have time to finish games and get bored easily, as the game isn't full of content but unnecessary quests and tasks.

Solution:

The Dark Swordsman fills this gap by offering a therapeutic gaming experience where the story, visuals, and atmosphere are designed to mirror the player's emotional journey. By guiding the protagonist through a cursed and haunting world toward redemption, players are encouraged to reflect, process emotions, and feel less alone. The game blends compelling narrative with realistic combat to create a unique space for emotional healing and meaningful connection.

My products will be mainly story based games, where the player would also be in the middle of action and content around, it would feel more like a movie where the player will be a main character. That's why the gameplay will be Linear and around 20 hours max.

Competitors



Analysis

Competitors Landscape

There are three AAA games with a target audience similar to that of Dark Swordsman: Hellblade, Dark Souls, and The Last of Us. Additionally, Indika, an indie-developed game, is a more comparable competitor in terms of team size and available resources.

Game	Overview	Metascore	Platforms	Engine
Hellblade	• Dark, emotional narrative • Strong female protagonist • Focus on mental health awareness	81	PlayStation, Xbox, PC	Unreal Engine 4
Dark Souls	• Challenging combats • Deep lore, minimal direct storytelling • Dark fantasy environments • Massive cult following	89	PlayStation, Xbox, PC	Dandelion
The Last of Us	• Powerful characters • Emotional story • Linear gameplay	93	PlayStation, Xbox, PC	Naughty Dog
Indika	• Emotional story supported with cutscenes • Linear story based game with philosophical meaning	80	PlayStation, Xbox, PC	Unreal Engine 4

MARKET SHARE

Overview:

As I mentioned in the Target Audience description, the most relevant audience is the fanbase of Berserk. By September 2023, the Berserk manga had over 60 million copies (Berserk (Manga), 2025) in circulation, including digital versions, making it one of the best-selling manga series of all time.

Berserk has also inspired a number of video games, including the Dynasty Warriors series (over 65 million copies sold), the Final Fantasy series (over 200 Million Copies Sold), the Dark Souls series (27 million copies sold), Bloodborne (7.46 million copies sold, Capcom's Devil May Cry (30 million units sold) and Dragon's Dogma series (1.7 million copies sold).

Total number of copies sold globally is 422.3 million.

Franchise/ Game Series	Copies Sold (millions)
Dynasty Warriors	65
Final Fantasy	200
Dark Souls	27
Bloodborne	7.46
Sekiro: Shadows Die Twice	10
Elden Ring	28.6
Capcom's Devil May Cry	30
Dragon's Dogma	1.7

ADJUSTED MARKETING SHARE

Methodology:

Now let's narrow the broad industry-wide figure based on our realistic assumption of market interest to the game and apply a Top-Down Market Sizing methodology (Market Sizing for Startups: How to Calculate TAM, SAM & SOM, 2025).

Let's assume 7% of these 422.3 million players are highly aligned with The Dark Swordsman's dark fantasy, emotional narrative, and challenge-driven gameplay.

Adjusted Addressable Market = 7% × 422.3M = ~29,561,000 million players.

MARKET SHARE SCENARIOS

Let's now model three realistic market share outcomes for a game based on Market Share Scenarios.

For the Conservative Cases we took the conversion rate 0.1% that is inline with the median conversion rate for Steam games (less than 500 Hype Score) in 2022, 2023 years. (Are Conversion Rates Dipping Over Time on Steam?, 2024).

Scenario	Conversion Rate	Estimated Unit Sales
Conservative	0.10%	29,561
Base Case	0.25%	73,903
Optimistic	0.50%	147,805
Viral Success	1%	295,610

COST ESTIMATION

The level of the game will be comparable to Indika, an emotional, story-driven experience supported by cinematic cutscenes.

Like Indika, The Dark Swordsman is a linear, narrative-focused game with deep philosophical themes. The price of Indika is €24.99 (Indika, n.d.), so we will use the same pricing model for The Dark Swordsman. In its first year, Indika generated €2.3 million in revenue (INDIKA – Stats on Steam, n.d.).`

Revenue Projection (at €25 per copy)

Scenario	Estimated Sales	Gross Revenue (€)
Conservative	29,561	739,025
Base Case	73,903	1,847,575
Optimistic	147,805	3,695,125
Viral Success	295,610	7,390,250

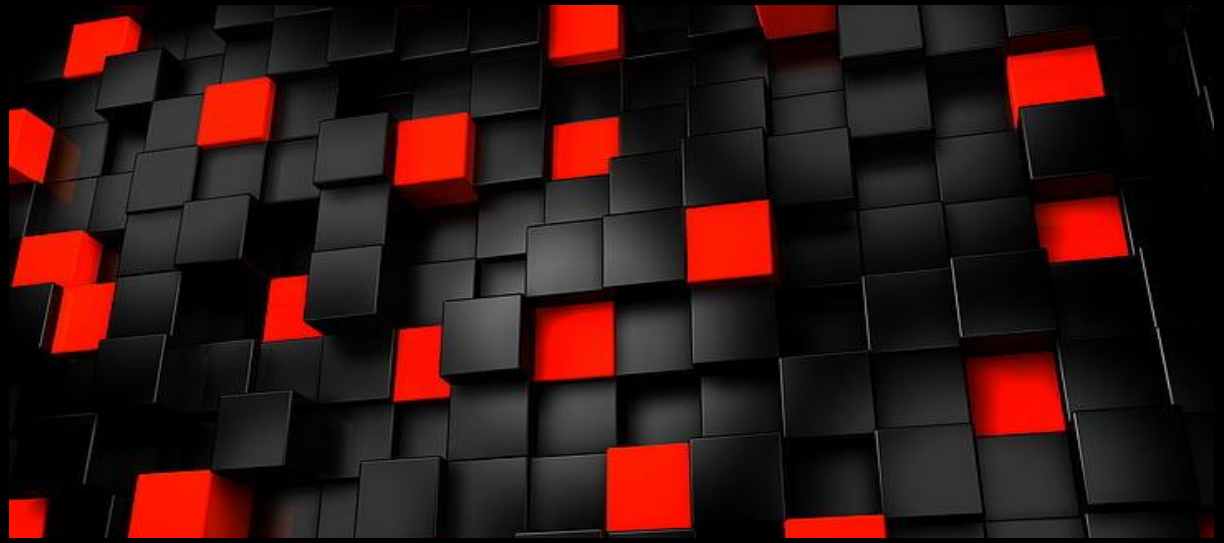
MARKET GROWTH PREDICTION

The global manga market size is expected to reach € 42.46 billion by 2030 from 2025 to 2030, with a compound annual growth rate (CAGR) of 18.7% from 2025 to 2030.

So we can assume that the interest for Manga-based games will grow proportionally in 5 years as well(Research and Markets, 2025).

Scenario	Estimated Sales 2024	Estimated Sales 2030 (+18.7%)	Estimated Gross Revenue 2025 (€)	Estimated Gross Revenue 2030 (€)
Conservative	8,400	9,971	739,025	877,223
Base Case	21,100	25,046	1,847,575	2,193,072
Optimistic	42,200	7,892	3,695,125	4,386,113
Viral Success	84,400	15,783	7,390,250	8,772,227

TEAM & PRODUCTION



COST

TEAM STRUCTURE & PROCESSES

Approach

At the beginning of the concept, I planned to do it alone before investing in my Startup, and then hire people, but I knew that the chance that someone would invest that huge amount of money to only one person is really low. That's why I started networking and asking professionals' opinions and if they would join my team for the potential production.

I asked some of the people I knew before, if they could advise me of someone who might be able to give me feedback and potentially join my team. That's how I connected with Danylo and Lillia, who provided me feedback but also agreed to join my startup idea if I want to fully start it. Furthermore, I connected with another person Nazariy who I got recommended as a good Unity developer.

Core team

So, our core team consists of me (Ruslan Rudniev, CEO and Game Producer), Nazariy (Senior Game Developer), Danylo (Senior Marketing Manager, will be in charge of Product Management, Marketing and Sales Activities), and our group mentor Lilia, who coaches the team through its organizational development.

While this team structure is sufficient to begin development, it is not enough to lead the game to success, we need additional talent and resources to make The Dark Swordsman a true success.

Key Processes

My Studio will apply Scrum as a core development methodology (Agile Game Development With Scrum: Teams, 2010). With 2-week sprints, I will be able to accept interim results and adjust requirements if the game needs change.

ROLES & RESPONSIBILITIES

#	Role	Responsibilities
1.	Product Owner	• Providing a strategic vision of the project/product • Clarifying, confirming, and prioritizing software requirements • Sprint results review and acceptance
2.	Unity Developer/ Tech Lead	• Develop and optimize core game systems using Unity • Lead technical decisions and ensure code quality • Collaborate with designers and artists to implement gameplay features
3.	Product Manager	• Define game vision, goals, and roadmap based on user needs • Coordinate cross-functional teams to ensure timely delivery • Monitor progress, gather feedback, and adjust priorities
4.	Game Designer	• Design core gameplay mechanics and combat systems • Structure story, missions, and level flow for emotional engagement • Collaborate with dev, art, and sound teams to align gameplay and vision
5.	3D Artist	• Create high-quality 3D models, environments, and props • Optimize assets for performance and visual consistency • Collaborate with design and tech teams to bring the game world to life
6.	Animator	• Design and animate characters, creatures, and cinematic sequences • Ensure smooth, movement aligned with game mechanics • Work closely with artists and developers to integrate animations into gameplay
7.	QA Tester	• Test game features to identify bugs and performance issues • Report and track issues to ensure timely fixes • Verify gameplay quality and consistency across builds



TEAM BUDGET

Period (months)	Position	Involvement	Salary (€)	Budget (€)
24	Product Owner/ Game Designer	100%	4000	96000
24	Unity Developer/ Tech Lead	100%	4000	96000
24	Product Manager	100%	4000	96000
24	3D Artist	50%	4000	3600
24	QA Tester	50%	3000	36000

Total cost: €360000

Salaries are calculated based on the available job market data and consulting with IT experts (Game Development Industry Salaries 2025, n.d.).

SOUND DESIGN COST

Category	Cost (€)
Sound Designer (Freelance)	5000
Original Soundtrack (Composer)	3000
Voice Acting (Actors & Direction)	2000

Total cost: €10000

The budget is calculated based on the information from audio production pricing guide (Audio Production Pricing Guide, 2024).

INFRASTRUCTURE & TOOLS

Category	Cost (€)	Notes
Game Engine Licenses	500	Unity is free until €100K revenue, but Pro or plugins may cost
3D Modeling Tools	1200	Blender (free) or Autodesk Maya/3ds Max (subscription)
Version Control (Git, etc.)	300	GitHub Teams, GitKraken, or similar tools
Project Management Tools	300	Tools like Trello Premium, or Jira
Cloud Storage & Backup	500	Google Drive, Dropbox, AWS, or Backblaze
Hardware	4000	PC, Monitor, etc
Software Licenses	1200	Adobe Creative Cloud, ReSharper, Visual Studio Pro, etc.
Miscellaneous Tools	1000	Asset store purchases, script packs, dev tools

Total cost: €9000

The budget was calculated based on these guidelines (How Much Does Indie Game Development Cost in 2025?, 2024).



OVERALL BUDGET

Category	Budget (€)
Team cost	360000
Sound Design	10000
Infrastructure and Tools	9000

Total cost: €379000

Marketing Campaign



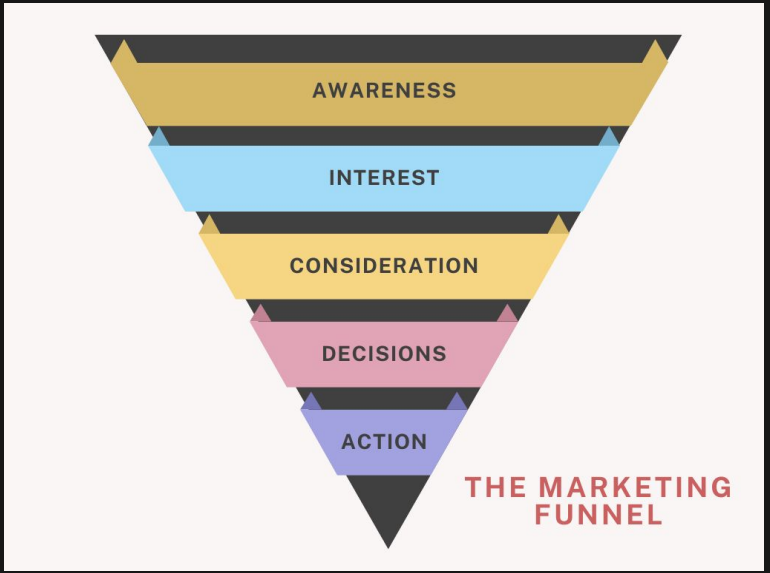
Marketing Funnel

Marketing Funnel

Overview:

Before considering the market strategies I will be using for proper game marketing, I chose a marketing model which I'm going to use as an example in order to get everything structured and in correct order. That's why I chose Marketing Funnel, as it describes all of the steps I should be taking in correct order, so the marketing campaign would be structured and effective.

Marketing Funnel has 5 different layers, which are for specific stages of marketing campaigns. I will apply my marketing strategies in that correct order.



Awareness & Interest

Overview:

The first step in my marketing campaign is to create awareness of my game. This stage is essential because players cannot engage with, consider, or purchase a product they do not know exists.

Building awareness lays the foundation for the entire marketing process by introducing the game to potential players and beginning to shape their perception. Without awareness, no further progress in the player journey is possible.



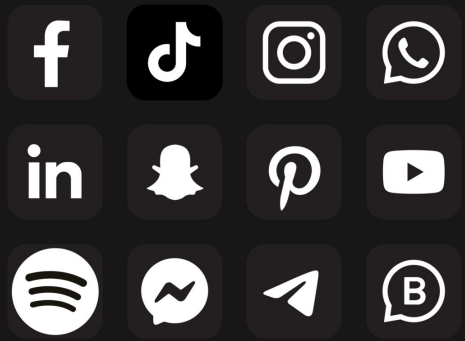
Social Media

Overview:

As the target audience for the game consists primarily of younger individuals who are highly active on social media, it is essential for the company to establish a strong presence across multiple platforms.

Social media serves as a powerful tool not only for raising awareness but also for building a community, generating anticipation, and maintaining long-term engagement. Moreover, my company will be using them during whole period, starting in late 2025 after starting production, in order to see people's reactions and feedback from target audience.

The active Phase will be started in mid 2027 right before & during Steam Fest.



Social Media: Tik Tok

Overview:

As I mentioned earlier, our target audience is mostly young adult from 18-25 year old, and one of the most popular social media among them is Tik Tok. That's why my company will be doing following steps in order to grab their attention and further interest in the game:

- Release a preview trailer in the late 2025 to see target audience reactions there and how viral it will go.
- Use hashtags "berserk", "dark fantasy", "the dark swordsman" in order to increase chances of trailer popping up in the recommendations
- In the Mid 2027 post Launch trailer & Gameplay clips during Steam Fest
- After opening preorders, post gameplay edits from the game that will most likely go viral. For example - emotional cutscene, action fight.

In summary, this platform will be used to post short-viral moments from the game, and further post shorts updates about the game.

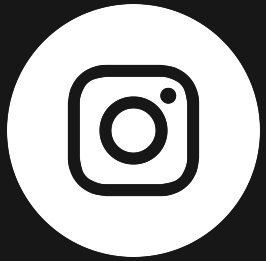
Social Media: Youtube

Overview:

Youtube is a platform that my company will be using in order to post video materials that last longer and aims to keep followers updated on the development process. In compare to Tik Tok, Youtube is a longer last platform for target audience, as the trailers which we're going to post will be recommended for much longer time. Additionally, this platform will collect all traffic from other platforms, as it's the most common app among people every age, which will only benefit us as our video materials will be recommended not only to Berserk fan base, but also other people who have interest in gaming in overall. That's why my company will be doing following steps:

- Release a preview trailer in the late 2025 and updating videos until mid 2027, where we discuss about our game in details.
- Ask popular influencers among this genre react to that trailer on streams and post video analyze of it. (JorRaptor; RealLifeRyan)
- In the Mid 2027 post Launch trailer & full Gameplay Video during Steam Fest & announcement video about free demo release.
- After Launch of the game post background video of the process making it + in the late 2028 post video about DLC & Customizations

Social Media: X | Instagram





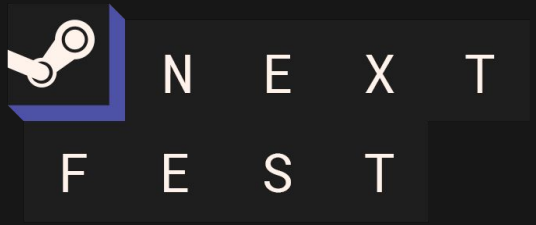
Overview:

Instagram and X (formerly Twitter) will serve as key platforms for community engagement.
Instagram will focus on delivering real-time updates, announcements, and game visuals primarily through Stories, in order to maintain an active and official brand presence. This ensures potential players can easily discover and recognize our company.

On other hand, X will play a more strategic role in community interaction. Due to its algorithm and conversational nature, I expect higher visibility and engagement there, rather than on Instagram, especially within niche communities. While much of the content will be cross-posted, X will be used for sharing trailers, starting discussions, and actively responding to community feedback to monitor sentiment and build deeper connections with our target audience.

In conclusion, both of social medias will be running full time starting in the late 2025, start of full production.

Conference



Overview:

As an independent developer releasing my first game, participating in large paid expos may not be financially viable. That's why my company will attend Steam Next Fest, most likely on June in 2027. During that event we are going to:

- Start first social media push by posting announcement and gameplay trailer via all the platforms in order to gain as much attention as we can.
- Releases a Demo version of the game on Steam
- Ask game journalists and youtube influencers to play the game and share their impression on platform.

Additionally, by offering a demo during this event, the game can move into the interest stage, where players begin to actively engage, by adding the game to the wishlist and posting about it online. Participating in this conference not only will increase visibility but also add community support during a crucial stage of the launch.

Recommendation Engine



Overview:

Following our Steam Fest attendance and realising a Demo version of the game, the Steamfest section on Steam will help us gain even more people hear about our game.

Furthermore, we will select relevant tags on the game, so people who's played similar games with them will more likely see our game in "Recommended for You" or "Similar to Games You've Played".

This will allow us gain more wishlists before actually realising/opening pre orders, in order to get more people buy our game.

Consideration & Decision: Demo Release

Overview:

After getting awareness and interest from our target audience , the next crucial steps are to help potential players evaluate the game and make the decision to purchase or engage more deeply. For my game, which targets Berserk fans and dark fantasy enthusiasts, these stages focus on providing convincing reasons to choose my game over alternatives.

Starting off with a Demo Release of the game during Steam Fest. This will allow potential players to try a meaningful portion of the game before purchase, increasing anticipation and building trust in the product. Providing a demo reduces uncertainty and helps convert interested players into actual buyers by letting them experience the gameplay, story, and atmosphere firsthand, and of course adding the game in Wishlist (which is the most important part).

Moreover, it’s a good opportunity to gain feedback about the game from customers, so the crucial parts would be fixed before the launch. In addition, it’s a good choice to track what the customer segment thinks about the game on platforms such as Discord, Reddit and X.



Pre-Order Bonuses

Overview:

After making customers add our game in the wishlist, two months after which is mid-late 2027, we will open the preorder so every person who added the game to the wishlist will receive a notification saying “A game you added to your wishlist is now available for pre-order”.

This preorder bonuses will include:

- Early access to the game - for preorder buyers we will give access to the game before it is released. Besides just getting a customer, it will also help the game in such a way as improving the game by receiving feedback from early players and at the same time popularize the game, which will bring even more audience.
- Artbook & Soundtrack- for preorder buyers we will get access to special artbooks, with multiple art visuals/concepts that have been used in the game (similar to Elden Ring: Nightreign strategy).



Those steps will help to convince the customers to buy the game more and create anticipation for it by giving the reward for the buyers, as after releasing the game those things will be part of Deluxe Bundle and will no longer be included in standard edition.

Community Engagement

Overview:

During all marketing campaign, my company will track reddit & discord Berserk communities in order to gain feedback from target audience and make sure that they know about our project, community such as r/Berserk will be a great tool to track that.

Furthermore, my company will create own discord server (the link to which one we're gonna pin on TikTok), so we would not just track other communities that might be interested in our game, but also create our own. This will give us possibilities to test the game with early adopters and communicate to target audience directly. Moreover, in order to attract that community in our Discord server, we will also post a link to it on other popular Berserk related communities on Discord.

In addition, it will also useful to track social media traffic with the name of our game, to see how popular and known it's already within the communities, by basically just searching our game name on Tik Tok search field and discussions on X (formerly Twitter). Those steps we're going to do constantly after starting teasing a first teaser trailer in the late 2025.



Action: Purchase

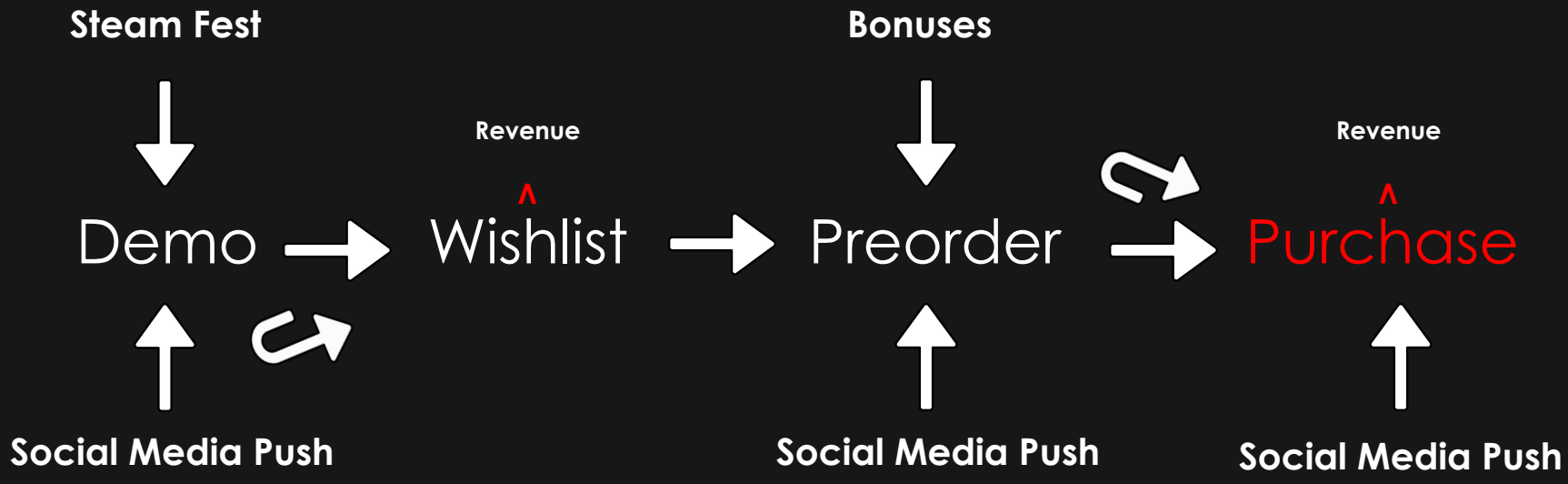


Overview:

Finally, after getting our users preorder the game, we will start getting our money revenue. Here you can see how all the Marketing campaigns supporting each other on each stage. First we get users know about the game with attending Steam Fest and making first social media push which includes posting announcement on all social medias mentioned before. Then, after letting them play the demo version, we will be expecting high amount of wishlist as this our primary target. This will also allow us to understand if those marketing steps really worked, and if we need to change the strategie.

Furthermore, after getting them add the game to wishlist, we will open the pre orders so all the people who added the game to wishlist would receive the notifications about it. In order to convenience our player to pre order the game more, we will include bonuses. And of course, we will do our Social Media push during the preorders open and further on a release of the game.

Road to Purchase



Monetization Strategies



Premium One-Time Purchase



Overview:

The Dark Swordsman will follow a traditional premium model, meaning players will pay once to access the full game experience. This approach fits well with the game's narrative-driven, emotional structure, where the story is meant to be complete and uninterrupted. As the game offers around 20 hours of structured, linear gameplay and focuses on immersion and psychological themes, a one-time payment ensures players can fully engage with the experience without distractions such as microtransactions or time-gated content.

The pricing will be set at €24.99, which is consistent with a successful indie title Indika. Since this is our first game, a fair one-time price also helps build trust with players, especially those in the Berserk fanbase and young adults seeking meaningful, story-heavy content. This monetization model supports the value-first vision of the game and allows players to make a one-time commitment for a complete gameplay through, up to 20 hours.

The official release date is scheduled in late 2027, but it also stays the same with a preorder (except for preorder customers will also receive a bonuses)

Release Date - Late 2027

DLC

Overview:

After the main game is released and the core audience is established, additional revenue can be generated through optional story expansions or DLCs. These would include new chapters, side stories, or additional gameplay modes, since the game is designed with strong narrative and emotional themes, expanding the story would resonate with players who are already invested in the world and characters. Moreover, it would not only serve as an extra monetization strategy but also help extend the game's lifespan and maintain community engagement long after release.

The DLC's pricing will remain at 4.99 euro. This strategy is commonly used by successful indie games such as Hollow Knight and Dead Space where paid expansions are released months after launch, giving the us time to refine content while also responding to player feedback.

Release Date - Mid 2028



Ads On



Overview:

In addition to the base game experience, my company will offer optional customization packs for players who want to personalize their journey. These packs will include cosmetic content such as alternate outfits for the protagonist, sword skins, cloaks, and armor variations. Inspired by other single player games that doesn't last long such as Resident Evil 2 *Remake* and Devil May Cry 5 that offer visual add-ons, this strategy will allow to get more money revenue from the game without ruining the story or gameplay. As The Dark Swordsman is built around emotional themes and atmospheric immersion, visual customization will add value for players who want a deeper sense of connection with the character and the game itself.

Each customization pack will range around €1.99 , depending on content complexity, such as different variations of skins or sound elements.

Release Date - Mid 2028 (in a month after DLC)

Release Date - Mid 2028

Bundles

Release Date - Late 2028

Overview:

To offer players additional value and to increase early revenue, my company will release two upgraded versions of the base game: a Deluxe Edition and an Extreme Edition. Release Date - Late 2028.

The Deluxe Edition will include bonus content such as the official soundtrack, a digital artbook with early concept designs and behind-the-scenes notes which were given for preorder buyers, and one or two exclusive customization items. This version is for fans who want to explore the game's artistic and musical depth while supporting the project further.

The Extreme Edition is designed for the most dedicated players and collectors. In addition to everything from the Deluxe Edition, it will include the deluxe edition content and additional game DLC. This version helps generate hype and rewards fans who are highly engaged in the community and lore.

These editions will allow it to increase its revenue per unit sold while giving back meaningful extras to fans who want more than the base game. It's a popular model used in many premium games like Elden Ring, The Last of Us Part I and works well for narrative-heavy titles where fans are invested in the world and characters.

Approximate Pricing:

- **Standard Edition**: €24.99
- **Deluxe Edition**: €29.99
- **Extreme Edition**: €34.99

This pricing structure gives players options based on their level of interest and budget while maximizing value perception and early funding for the development team.

Press Kit



Press Kit: Contact Details

Here you can see a press kit of our game, that will helps us while contacting journalist & other influencers so they could have a key words they need to tell and have a quick impression of the game itself:

- **Developer:** RR Team
- **Name:** The Dark Swordsman: The Beginning of the End
- **Release Date:** Late 2027
- **Platforms:** PC
- **Price:** 24.99 euro
- **Availability:** Digital Download
- **Languages:** English
- **ESRB:** 18+
- **Website:** rus-rud.com

Press Kit: Game Overview

Description:

The Dark Swordsman: The Beginning of the End is a dark fantasy, story-focused adventure game played from a first-person view. You play as the Black Swordsman, a warrior cursed to live forever unless he defeats the demons that keep him alive. The game tells a deep and emotional story about revenge, regret, and the hope for freedom. Inspired by the story of Berserk and Dark Souls atmosphere, it features a dark, medieval world, realistic sword fighting, and powerful cutscenes that pull you into the main character's journey.

Gameplay:

The gameplay gives an opportunity to try a new realistic fighting mechanic, as most of the game players will use the infamous black sword. The unique feature of this gameplay is not just with fighting mechanics on swords, but also realism of that process, as if you got hit by a sword (for example in the heart) you will die, there is no HP for the player and who is against him. Furthermore, the player will be fully engaged with the story, as there will be a lot of cinematic cutscenes.

Atmosphere & Visual Design:

The atmosphere is a balance between dark fantasy, psychological horror, and emotional depth, designed to make players feel both the weight of the protagonist's past and the oppressive environment he's trapped in.

Press Kit: Game Overview

Benefits:

- Fully clean screen without UI
- Unique fighting mechanic
- Deep storytelling
- Realistic style
- Dark Fantasy world setting
- Short and engaging gameplay
- Only up to 20 hours of gameplay fulfilled with main content

How to play:

- Follow the story supported by cinematic cutscene
- Use keyboard & mouse for movement and fighting
- Complete quests



Press Kit: Game Overview



Main Mechanics Combat:

Players will wield a sword to fight off enemies, with mechanics involving attacking & defending to defeat various types of demons and soldiers. Exploration: Players will explore different environments such as forests, villages, and warfield's, interacting with NPCs and discovering the lore. Cut scenes: During the game the player will see different motion cutscenes, as it’s more story based game and atmosphere.





Store Font: Steam

Overview:

While releasing the game on Steam, for us it will be important to attract players to view our page, that's why my company will use clear text descriptions and supporting visuals on the Steam page.

Short Description (Main Page):

The Dark Swordsman: The Beginning of the End is a first-person, story-driven dark fantasy adventure. Assume the role of the Black Swordsman, a cursed warrior doomed to eternal life unless he can defeat the demons that tether his soul.

Journey through a grim medieval world inspired by the atmosphere of *Dark Souls* and the narrative depth of *Berserk*. Engage in realistic sword combat and experience a powerful, emotional story of vengeance, sorrow, and the search for freedom. With cinematic cutscenes and immersive storytelling, *The Dark Swordsman* invites you on a haunting journey into darkness.



Store Font: Steam

Features:

- Combat: Players will wield a sword to fight off enemies, with mechanics involving attacking & defending to defeat various types of demons and soldiers.
- Exploration: Players will explore different environments such as forests, villages, and warfield's, interacting with NPCs and discovering the lore.
- Cut scenes: During the game the player will see different motion cutscenes, as it’s more story based game and atmosphere.
- Immersive World: Players will experience a dark, atmospheric world where every action feels significant. The emotional weight of the protagonist's journey, including moments of regret and self-reflection, will encourage players to connect with his struggles.
- Impact: The moral complexity of the protagonist’s choices, especially during the pivotal moments (like the decision to visit his old love), will make players reflect on their own choices in real life.
- Emotional Engagement: The game will take players on a rollercoaster of emotions, from the protagonist’s past love to the final philosophical reflections about fate and self determination. These moments will make players question the nature of revenge, redemption, and what it means to truly live.

My Company



My Company

Overview:

My company is a startup gaming studio working on my first game to help others cope with inner sorrow. I believe in the social impact of storytelling and strive to develop titles that are not only technically innovative and artistically compelling but also emotionally healing and inclusive.

Mission Statement
I'm committed to creating powerful narrative-driven games that explore deep emotional and psychological themes. *The Dark Swordsman* is more than a game, it's a meaningful journey through darkness, regret, and redemption. My mission is to support players who feel lost, disconnected, or alone by providing a compelling, immersive experience that resonates with their inner struggles and helps them reflect on the value of life and hope and at the same time create my own fan base of the product my company will be producing.

My Company

Vision Statement:

To become a leading voice in emotional and psychological storytelling within the gaming industry.

I aspire to build a universe of games, books, and interactive experiences that touch lives, inspire self-reflection, and offer comfort to those facing emotional hardships. Through bold narratives, artistic world-building, and innovative mechanics, my company aims to redefine what it means for games to be both entertainment and a source of healing.

I envisioned *The Dark Swordsman* as the foundation of a lasting legacy, a story that starts with one game and grows into a powerful franchise with global impact, inspiring players to not only play, but to feel, reflect, and grow.

KPIs

Business Planning - Your Game

		Month																			
Business Change	**Begin state**	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15	16	17	18	Sales Total	**Target state**
	Working prototype	Demo Release / Pre-Orders Open				Launch of the game								DLC/ Costomizations/Merchendize Release							
	Basic testing																				
	No business																				
KPIs	Downloads	100	100	100	100	5000	5000	5000	5000	5000	5000	5000	5000	2000	2000	2000	2000	2000	2000		
	Whishlist	400	400	400	400	4000	1000	1000	1000	1000	1000	1000	1000	1000	1000	1000	1000	1000	1000		
Projects & Inititives	Product	Demo Release		Beta testing/Iteration		Launch of the game	Iterate user feedback / fixing bugs					Polished version		Additonal Release							
	Product 2													DLC	Skins		Bundles				
	Businnes																				
	Resources																				
Marketing	Stable Online	Regular Marketing and Braning Activitties																			
	Online	Conference		Recommendation Engine		Influencer Marketing		Community Engament													
	Offline																				
Costs	Team	€ 19,000	€ 19,000	€ 19,000	€ 19,000	€ 19,000	€ 19,000	€ 19,000	€ 19,000	€ 19,000	€ 19,000	€ 19,000	€ 19,000	€ 19,000	€ 19,000	€ 19,000	€ 19,000	€ 19,000	€ 19,000		€ 342,000
	Marketing	€ 11,600	€ 2,100	€ 2,100	€ 6,100	€ 17,600	€ 100	€ 100	€ 100	€ 2,600	€ 5,100	€ 100	€ 100	€ 2,600	€ 100	€ 100	€ 100	€ 100	€ 100		€ 50,800
	Production	€ 375	€ 375	€ 375	€ 375	€ 375	€ 375	€ 375	€ 375	€ 375	€ 375	€ 375	€ 375	€ 375	€ 375	€ 375	€ 375	€ 375	€ 375		€ 6,750
Revenue	Sale € 25.00	$ 2,500.00	€ 2,500	€ 2,500	€ 2,500	€ 125,000	€ 125,000	€ 125,000	€ 125,000	€ 125,000	€ 125,000	€ 125,000	€ 125,000	€ 50,000	€ 50,000	€ 50,000	€ 50,000	€ 50,000	€ 50,000		€ 1,310,000 Overall Sales
	Additional cont $ 9.99																				
																					€ -
Profit/loss		€ -28,475	€ -18,975	€ -18,975	€ -22,975	€ 88,025	€ 105,525	€ 105,525	€ 105,525	€ 103,025	€ 100,525	€ 105,525	€ 105,525	€ 28,025	€ 30,525	€ 30,525	€ 30,525	€ 30,525	€ 30,525		€ 910,450 Total profit
Cash		€ -28,475	€ -47,450	€ -66,425	€ -89,400	€ -1,375	€ 104,150	€ 209,675	€ 315,200	€ 418,225	€ 518,750	€ 624,275	€ 729,800	€ 757,825	€ 788,350	€ 818,875	€ 849,400	€ 879,925	€ 910,450		€ -89,400 Max loss during 18 month period

KPI Roadmap Overview (18 months)

Development & Release Milestones

- Start: Working Prototype (5% bugs reported max, all bugs fixed before release)
- Milestone: Demo Release & Pre-Orders (400 downloads, 1600 wishlists, 80% positive reviews)
- Launch: Full Game Release (4000 downloads, 11000 wishlists, 70% positive reviews)
- Post-launch: DLC, Customizations, Merchandise (12000 downloads, 6000 wishlists, 70% positive reviews)

Strategic KPIs

- Total profit: € 910,450
- Sales Total: € 1310000
- Max loss during 18 month period: € -89,400
- Price: € 25.00

Timeline

- 18-month roadmap from prototype to post-launch revenue phases

Budget

- € 399,550 [Team: € 342,000; Marketing: € 50800; Tools: €6750]

KPI Roadmap Overview (18 months)

Expences		1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15	16	17	18	Expenses Total
	Period	Pre-order opens / Demo Release				Launch of the game								DLC/ Costomizations/Merchendize Release						
	Stage	Beta testing		Demo Release/Iteration		Launch of the game	Iterate user feedback / fixing bugs					Polished version		Additonal Release						
Team Expenses	Product Owner	4000	4000	4000	4000	4000	4000	4000	4000	4000	4000	4000	4000	4000	4000	4000	4000	4000	4000	72000
	Unity Developer/ Tech Lead	4000	4000	4000	4000	4000	4000	4000	4000	4000	4000	4000	4000	4000	4000	4000	4000	4000	4000	72000
	Product Manager	4000	4000	4000	4000	4000	4000	4000	4000	4000	4000	4000	4000	4000	4000	4000	4000	4000	4000	72000
	Game Designer (50% involvement)	2000	2000	2000	2000	2000	2000	2000	2000	2000	2000	2000	2000	2000	2000	2000	2000	2000	2000	36000
	3D Artist (50% involvement)	2000	2000	2000	2000	2000	2000	2000	2000	2000	2000	2000	2000	2000	2000	2000	2000	2000	2000	36000
	QA Tester	3000	3000	3000	3000	3000	3000	3000	3000	3000	3000	3000	3000	3000	3000	3000	3000	3000	3000	54000
	Total	**19000**	**19000**	**19000**	**19000**	**19000**	**19000**	**19000**	**19000**	**19000**	**19000**	**19000**	**19000**	**19000**	**19000**	**19000**	**19000**	**19000**	**19000**	**342000**
Infrastructure & Tools	**Game Engine Licenses, 3D Modeling Tools, Version Control (Git, etc.), Project Management Tools, Cloud Storage & Backup Hardware, Software Licenses, Miscellaneous Tools**	**375**	**375**	**375**	**375**	**375**	**375**	**375**	**375**	**375**	**375**	**375**	**375**	**375**	**375**	**375**	**375**	**375**	**375**	**6750**
Marketing (Awareness)	Social Media Content Creation & Mgmt (TikTok, YouTube, X)	5000 2500				 2500			5000	 2500				 2500	5000					15000 10000
	Game Store Promotion (Steam/Epic Front Page)	2500		2500		2500								2500						10000
	Steam Fest																			
Marketing (Consideration & Decision)	Website Development + Hosting	100	100	100	100	100	100	100	100	100	100	100	100	100	100	100	100	100	100	1800
	Steam Prep + Launch	2000	2000	2000	2000															8000
	Influencer Marketing (Twitch/YouTube)	2500				2500				2500				2500						10000
	Email Marketing + Press Kit Distribution	2000																		2000
	Analytics Tools & Tracking	1000																		1000
Marketing (Action)	Pre Order Launch Campaign	4000			4000															8000
	Final Paid Ads Push										5000									5000
	Community Management + Launch Support					5000														5000
	Additional Influencer/PR Push					10000														10000
	Total	**11600**	**2100**	**2100**	**6100**	**17600**	**100**	**100**	**100**	**2600**	**5100**	**100**	**100**	**2600**	**100**	**100**	**100**	**100**	**100**	50800

Timeline: Development Stages

Early 2025
Concepting & Prototyping

Mid/Late 2025 – Mid 2026
Full Production + Iterative User Testing (Agile Workflow)

Late 2026 – Early 2027
Final Testing & Polishing

Mid 2027
Start of the Marketing Active Phase

Late 2027
Release on Platforms

Mid 2028
Release DLC|Customization|Bundles



Timeline: Current State

Mid-2025 - Concepting & Prototyping

As of mid-2025, I've successfully completed the GDD, which outlines all core mechanics, systems, player flows, and gameplay loops. Alongside, I found well balanced development team, including designers, artists, and programmers. All aligned with the project vision and timeline.

Late 2025 – Start of Full Production

We are preparing to enter the full production phase. At this stage, we will also launch official social media accounts (Instagram, X/Twitter, YouTube) and open Discord Server in order to start building our own community. The first content posted will be:

- An official **announcement of production**
- A short **announcement trailer**

These will serve to establish a presence, begin audience engagement, and draw the attention of early followers—especially from niche communities like the **Berserk fanbase**.

Timeline: Production

2025 to Early 2027 – Development & Community Engagement

During this phase:

- Core development of the game will continue
- We will maintain ongoing communication with our audience across Discord, X, and Instagram
- Regular updates, concept art, development logs, and behind the scenes content will be shared via Youtube page
- We will gather community feedback on the game by interviewing focus groups

This phase ensures that we remain aligned with both our vision and the expectations of our future player base.

These will serve to establish a presence, begin audience engagement, and draw the attention of early followers—especially from niche communities like the **Berserk fanbase**.

Timeline: Pre Launch Campaign

Summer 2027 – Steam Fest & Demo Launch

By mid-2027, we plan to:

- Complete the main production phase
- Attend **Steam Next Fest** to showcase the game to a broader PC gaming audience
- Launch a **fully playable demo** to collect detailed player feedback and assess interest

This will be a critical opportunity for traction, wishlist growth, and influencer exposure.

Late 2027 – Pre Order Launch

Approximately **two months after the demo**, assuming we receive strong reception and hit internal benchmarks, we will:

- Open **pre-orders** for the game
- Offer **pre-order bonuses** including early access, art book and original soundtrack

Timeline: Launch of the game

End of 2027 – Full Game Release

The game will be officially available to play on Steam(PC) by the end of 2027. This launch will be supported by:

- A final push marketing campaign which includes a posting release trailer and announcement via all social medias and platforms we're going to use.

Early to Mid-2028 – Post Launch Support & Polishing

After release, we will focus on:

- Bug fixing and technical optimization
- Actively listening to player feedback through our Discord server and socials
- Ensuring the game is stable and polished for long-term replayability

Timeline: DLC & Customization

Late 2028 – DLC & Customization Packs

If by mid-2028 :

- Our KPI targets (sales, active players, retention) are met or exceeded
- The community shows strong desire for more content (monitored via polls, Discord chatter, and engagement metrics)

Then in late-2028 we will release:

- DLCs expanding the story
- Cosmetic/customization packs
- Bundles

By the end of 2028

All versions of the game (standard, deluxe, extreme) will be fully available to players.



LET'S CONNECT!

If you're interested in the project have questions, ideas, or want to collaborate? Get in touch with me!

Ruslan Rudniev,
CEO and Game Producer



